

When records outlive generations

Some achievements endure for decades, remaining **benchmarks** of excellence long after the athletes who set them have stepped away from competition.

Suresh Menon

Ahead of the Olympics, I often carry out an exercise: take any Indian national record and see at which Olympics the respective athlete might have won gold. For example, Gurindervir Singh ran the 100m in 10.09 this year, the fastest by an Indian. That would have fetched him gold at the 1980 Moscow Olympics (Alan Wells ran 10.25). So, India is, in effect, 46 years behind in that event. There's nothing scientific here, just a conversation opener (or stopper).

The mile world record too fell this year, with Britain's Josh Kerr going past Moroccan Hicham El Guerrouj's 1999 mark. What of other records from the last century that are still standing? The women's 800m record, set by the Czech Jarmila Kratochvilova, is the oldest — 1:53.28, set in 1983.

In 1988, women set world records in the 100m, 200m, long jump, discus throw and heptathlon that haven't been beaten yet.

The stars were Florence Griffith-Joyner ('Flo Jo'), who ran the 100m in 10.49 and the 200m in 21.34, and Jackie Joyner-Kersey, her sister-in-law, who broke the heptathlon record. Both were trained by Bob Kersee, who picked up a reputation as a 'drugs coach' (nothing was proved). It didn't follow that the records were tainted (although Flo Jo's best the previous year had been 10.96). Interestingly, some authorities don't recognise Flo Jo's 100m record, claiming it was wind-assisted.

Marita Koch's 1985 record in the 400m remains,



Still standing: The women's 800m record, set by the Czech Jarmila Kratochvilova, is the oldest — 1:53.28, set in 1983. GETTY IMAGES

although in her case there is documentary evidence that she was part of East Germany's state-sponsored drugs scheme.

Interestingly, the men's records from the last century are mainly in the field events. An exception is El Guerrouj's mark in the 1500m. Bob Beamon's 8.90m long jump at the Mexico Olympics, the 'Leap of the Century', didn't last the century. Mike Powell ensured that with an 8.95m effort a quarter of a century later.

At the World Championships four years later, Jonathan Edwards broke the triple jump record at his first attempt with 18.16m. In less than half an hour he broke it again, with 18.29m. Edwards didn't participate in the 1991 World Championships because, as a Christian, he didn't compete on Sundays. In later years, after many discussions with his

father, who was a vicar, he changed his mind, arguing that his God-given talent had to be used for competitive athletics if it was to mean anything at all.

Neeraj Chopra's former coach, the Czech javelin legend Jan Zelezny, set the mark of 98.48m in 1996, which still stands, as do the marks set by Javier Sotomayor (high jump), Jurgen Schult (discus) and Yuriy Sedykh (hammer), the last two having stood for 40 years.

India's oldest record was broken this year when Sawan Barwal clocked 2:11:58 at the NN Marathon Rotterdam, erasing the 1978 mark of Shivnath Singh. PT Usha's LA Olympics (1984) mark of 55.42 in the 400m hurdles was equalled by Vithya Ramraj three years ago, not broken.

"I hope my record will outlive me," said Joyner-Kersey. It may be the secret desire of some athletes.